Castle Death

Dungeon World starter by Mark Tygart. Adapted for Orcus by Chris Sakkas. Released under a Creative Commons 4.0 license. Recommended for heroes of levels 1 through 3.

Questions

- What brings you here, to Castle Death?
- Have you been in this adventuring business for long?
- What stories have you heard about the cruel tyrant said to have once ruled this place?
- What do the locals say they see or hear at night when the battlements are observed from a safe distance?
- What rumors of wealth are associated with the keep?
- Do you believe in the prophecy of the return of a rightful lord?

Impressions

- A stark silhouette against a stormy sky
- Ancient stonework, vine-cloaked walls
- A flash of lightning, deafening thunder
- Rain and wind across the crumbling battlements
- The gaping maw of the front gate
- A raised portcullis, like a line of iron teeth
- The stench of goblin
- The flickering light of torches, here and there
- A high-ceiling passage, dense with thick webs
- Rich and soiled furnishings, looted from elsewhere
- The distant sound of guttural laughter

Creeping Doom

If the denizens of Castle Death have reason to be suspicious ...

After a short rest, the GM chooses one.

- Bongaz prepares a Potion of Healing from his treasure trove.
- Mordrivaug dons the Ring of Shadows and slips out of his chambers to investigate.
- The torches in one room burn low, threatening to plunge it into darkness mid-encounter.
- Night approaches. Skeletal wretches gain +2 Speed.
- The goblins light bonfires for their next meal. Smoke spreads.

After a long rest, the GM chooses one.

- Weak-hearted goblins are rooted out. No option for goblin recruits.
- Hobgoblin soldiers arrive.
- Mordrivaug breaks the Lightblade in two. It will need repairs.
- Some treasure is sent away as tribute.
- The Book of Wonders is cleverly hidden.

Places

Hidden Sanctuary The first time you take a short rest in the Hidden Sanctuary, one hero makes a Dungeoneering check (DC 15). On a success, choose three. On a failure, choose one.

- You recover as if you had taken a long rest
- You each collect an additional 1d6 days' worth of rations
- You experience a vision (ask the GM what you see)
- You do not collapse into mystical sleep

Throne Room When you enter the Throne Room for the first time, each make Stealth and Perception checks (DC 14).

If most succeed on Perception, they notice the Pit Traps.

If most succeed on Stealth, Bongaz is asleep.

Discoveries

☐ **Goblin Recruit** A goblin lackey joins the party. Later heroes can start with the goblin ancestry.

☐ **Grave Goods** Salamander Amulet, Old Map, gold cartouche (250 gold)

> **Salamander Amulet** *An arrowhead-shaped amulet of polished black onyx on a square-linked chain.*
>
> **Old Map** *A 3'x3' piece of vellum, soft as silk from a lifetime of folding and unfolding. Fingerprints, scratch marks, and unidentifiable stains (blood? tea?) obscure a detailed architectural schematic in faded brown ink.* A floorplan of Castle Death. You may discern the location of the Hidden Sanctuary, and one or more of the Architect's Pit Traps.

☐ **Goblin Bank** Codex of Wonders, 60 gold, 300 silver

> **Codex of Wonders** *A thick tome with a latching cover, bound in canvas that appears gray, but upon close examination swirls with living color.*

☐ **Bongaz's Stash** Potion of Healing, 70 gold, 100 silver, ruby earring (100 gold)

☐ **Mordrivaug's Horde** The Lightblade, Ring of Shadows, Deed to Castle Death, 2 Potions of Healing, 260 gold, ruby earring (100 gold)

> **The Lightblade** *A short sword glowing white, as easy to wield as a willow switch.*
>
> **Ring of Shadows** *A simple band of smoky quartz.*
>
> **Deed to Castle Death** A sheaf of yellowed pages, tied up with string. When you decipher the ridiculous legal language of the Deed, you learn that a member of your party is the true and rightful heir to Castle Death! Ask the GM who it is.

Terrain

Chequerboard Level 1, 50 XP

Each square is either black or white. On odd rounds, spikes attack creatures standing on black squares. On even rounds, spikes attack creatures standing on white squares. +4 vs Reflex; 1d10+3 damage.

Marble Queen ● Cover

Medium. **AC/Ref** 5, **Fort** 10, **HP** 20

DC 12 Athletics to rotate. While the queen faces the chequerboard, pattern swaps: on odd rounds, spikes attack white. On even, spikes attack black.

Rubble ● Difficult Terrain

Pile of Bones ● Difficult Terrain

After moving through this space, remove this terrain. The bones are scattered.

Smoke ● Lightly Obscuring

Statue ● Cover

Medium. **AC/Ref** 5, **Fort** 10, **HP** 20

Architect's pit trap Level 1, 50 XP

Appears as cobblestone (notice DC 12 reveals hinge)

+4 vs Reflex (all creatures standing in the area). On a hit, the target falls 10 feet into the pit (1d10 falling damage).

Goblin Dart Trap Level 1, 25 XP

Appears as chequerboard (notice DC 12 reveals hole)

+4 vs Fortitude. On a hit, the target takes 5 persistent poison damage (save ends). *Aftereffect:* The target is restrained (save ends).

Monsters

Goblin Lackey Level 1, 100 XP

Yellow-eyed, snaggle-toothed, underfed; oppressed.

HP 29. **AC** 15. **Fort** 12, **Ref** 14, **Will** 13. **Spd** 6.

Assault En Masse Once per turn, if an adjacent goblin ally charges, you may charge.

Standard Actions

Crude Weapon +6 vs AC: 1d10+3 damage.

Pelt Ranged 10, +4 vs Ref: target is off-guard until the end of their next turn.

Move Action

Disorganized Panic Shift up to your Speed. You must move as far away from enemies as possible.

Skeletal Wretch Level 1 Mook, 25 XP

HP 1. **AC** 17. **Fort** 14, **Ref** 13, **Will** 13. **Spd** 6. **Immune** poison, **Resist** necrotic 5, **Weak** radiant 5.

Mook Missed attacks never damage you.

Increase Ranks ● *Summoning* If the skeletal wretch begins its turn adjacent to a corpse or pile of bones, they create one skeletal wretch ally in that space, then remove the corpse/pile of bones.

Standard Actions

Rusted Weapon +6 vs AC: 5 damage, and the target is marked.

Drag Them Down +4 vs Fort: target falls prone.

Giant Spider Level 2 Elite, 250 XP

HP 68. **AC** 16. **Fort** 14, **Ref** 13, **Will** 15. **Spd** 6, climb 4. **Saves** +2.
Action Points ☐

Tremorsense 5. *Web Stride*.

Skitter If an attack causes you to become bloodied, you may move up to your Speed.

Standard Actions

Fangs +7 vs AC: 1d12+3 damage, +1d8 against slowed, restrained or immobilized targets.

Clot of Webbing Ranged 10, +5 vs Ref: the target is slowed (save ends).

Swift Action

Inject 1 slowed enemy, +5 vs Fort: the target is stunned until the end of their next turn.

Bongaz, Bugbear Overlord Level 3 Elite, 300 XP

Hulking, gray-skinned, goblin-blooded, with a head, neck, and back covered with thinning black hair. Self-proclaimed master of Castle Death and bullying ruler of its goblin inhabitants. Surprisingly sneaky, always hungry, not above eating his subjects.

HP 90. **AC** 15. **Fort** 16, **Ref** 14, **Will** 15. **Spd** 6. **Saves** +2.
Action Points ☐

Eat The Weak Each time an adjacent enemy becomes bloodied, you can make a morningstar attack against them as a free action.

Standard Action

Morningstar ● **Weapon** +8 vs AC: 1d12+7 damage, and push 2 squares. +1d12 damage against rattled, surprised or flanked targets.

Swift Actions

Disarm +6 vs Fort: target loses a weapon or their shield.

Bully The Weak (encounter) Near burst 5, +6 vs Will: bloodied creatures become rattled until the end of their next turn.

Command Lesser Goblins ● **Charm** (refresh ⚄⚄⚅) Far burst 1 within 10, goblin allies. the target can make a basic attack or move their speed.

Mordrivaug, Dragon of Death Level 3 Boss, 750 XP

The true master of Castle Death.

HP 156. **AC** 17. **Fort** 15, **Ref** 14, **Will** 16. **Spd** 5, fly 8. **Saves** +5. **Resist** fire 5, **Weak** radiant 5. **Action Points** ☐☐

Standard Actions

Tail Swipe Reach 2, +8 vs AC: 1d12+4 damage, and push 2.

Bite +8 vs Ref: 1d12+4 damage, and the target is rattled until the end of their next turn.

Multiattack You make a tail swipe and a bite attack, against different targets.

Black Fire ● **Fire** (refresh ⚄⚅) Near spray 5, +6 vs Ref: 1d12+4 damage. Does double damage to objects and terrain.

Swift Actions

Demand Tribute ● **Charm** (refresh ⚄⚅) Ranged 10, +6 vs Will: the target must drop its most valuable item and cannot pick it up again until the end of the encounter.

Disdain (encounter) At the start of your turn, make a saving throw against each condition affecting you. You can take this action even if you are stunned.

Counter

Word of Command Ranged 10, one enemy moving towards you or targeting you with an attack, +6 vs Will: they stop moving/ cannot target you with that attack.

Codex of Wonders

A thick tome with a latching cover, bound in canvas that appears gray, but upon close examination swirls with living color.

When you use the Codex to research an artifact or magic item, you may ask three questions about the object of your study. Make an Arcana check (DC 12 + the item's level). On a success, the GM will answer two of the questions correctly. On a failure, the GM will answer two of the questions incorrectly.

Magic Item Level 3 ● Wondrous Item
680 gold

Ring of Shadows

A simple band of smoky quartz.

Power ● Daily (Swift Action)
You become invisible (save maintains). While you are invisible, you are weakened. You can end both effects by taking off the ring as a swift action.

Each time you activate the ring, the GM chooses one side effect:

- All light sources in your vicinity flicker and go out
- You draw the attention of nearby creatures of shadow
- You'll have to make a Will save (DC 15) to take the ring off

Magic Item Level 4 ● Ring
840 gold

Evasive Maneuvers At-Will

Reaction Action

Trigger An enemy misses you with an attack

Effect You shift 1 square.

Puck

Goblin Ancestry

Small fey humanoid

Speed 6 squares

Languages ☑ Common, ☑ Goblin

Lightning Reflexes You gain the Lightning Reflexes feat.

Evasive Maneuvers Add the *Evasive maneuvers* talent.

Lightning Reflexes
+2 Reflex. *Level 11,* +3 instead. *Level 21,* +4 instead.

Evasive Maneuvers PUCK
Add *Evasive maneuvers* to your powers.

Salamander Amulet

An arrowhead-shaped amulet of polished black onyx on a square-linked chain.

You resist 5 fire.
Level 11 Resist 10 fire, *Level 21* Resist 15 fire.

Magic Item Level 3 ● Neck
680 gold

The Lightblade

A short sword glowing white, as easy to wield as a willow switch.

Basic and at-will attacks do radiant damage in addition to any other damage type.
While unsheathed, the Lightblade casts light like a torch.

Magic Item Level 2 ● Weapon
520 gold

